# Lexeme



From Wikipedia, the free encyclopedia

*For its use in the context of computer science, see Lexeme (computer science).*

A **lexeme** (/ˈlɛksiːm/) is a unit of lexical meaning that underlies a set of words that are related through inflection. It is a basic abstract unit of meaning,[1] a unit of morphological analysis in linguistics that roughly corresponds to a set of forms taken by a single root word. For example, in the English language, *run*, *runs*, *ran* and *running* are forms of the same lexeme, which can be represented as RUN.[note 1]

One form, the lemma (or citation form), is chosen by convention as the canonical form of a lexeme. The lemma is the form used in dictionaries as an entry's headword. Other forms of a lexeme are often listed later in the entry if they are uncommon or irregularly inflected.

## Description [edit]

The notion of the lexeme is central to morphology,[2] the basis for defining other concepts in that field. For example, the difference between inflection and derivation can be stated in terms of lexemes:

- Inflectional rules relate a lexeme to its forms.
- Derivational rules relate a lexeme to another lexeme.

A lexeme belongs to a particular syntactic category, has a certain meaning (semantic value), and in inflecting languages, has a corresponding inflectional paradigm. That is, a lexeme in many languages will have many different forms. For example, the lexeme RUN has a present third person singular form *runs*, a present non-third-person singular form *run* (which also functions as the past participle and non-finite form), a past form *ran*, and a present participle *running*. (It does not include *runner, runners, runnable* etc.) The use of the forms of a lexeme is governed by rules of grammar. In the case of English verbs such as RUN, they include subject–verb agreement and compound tense rules, which determine the form of a verb that can be used in a given sentence.

In many formal theories of language, lexemes have subcategorization frames to account for the number and types of complements. They occur within sentences and other syntactic structures.

## Decomposition [edit]

A language's lexemes are often composed of smaller units with individual meaning called morphemes, according to root morpheme + derivational morphemes + affix (not necessarily in that order), where:

- The root morpheme is the primary lexical unit of a word, which carries the most significant aspects of semantic content and cannot be reduced to smaller constituents.[3]
- The derivational morphemes carry only derivational information.[4]
- The affix is composed of all inflectional morphemes, and carries only inflectional information.[5]

The compound root morpheme + derivational morphemes is often called the stem.[6] The decomposition stem + desinence can then be used to study inflection.

## See also [edit]

- Ending (linguistics)
- Inflection
- Lemma
- Lexicon
- Lexical item
- Lexical word vs. grammatical word
- Marker (linguistics)
- Multiword expression
- Null morpheme
- Root (linguistics)
- Stem
- Syntagma (linguistics)
- Word family

*Linguistics portal*
*Language portal*

## Notes [edit]

1. ^ RUN is here intended to display in small caps. Software limitations may result in its display either in full-sized capitals (RUN) or in full-sized capitals of a smaller font. Either is regarded as an acceptable substitute for genuine small caps.

## References [edit]

1. ^ *The Cambridge Encyclopedia of The English Language*. David Crystal. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1995. p. 118. ISBN 0521401798.
2. ^ Bonami O, Boyé G, Dal G, Giraudo H, Namer F (2018). Bonami O, Boyé G, Dal G, Giraudo H, Namer F (eds.). *The lexeme in descriptive and theoretical morphology* (pdf). Berlin: Language Science Press. doi:10.5281/zenodo.1402520. ISBN 978-3-96110-110-8.
3. ^ "SIL Glossary of Linguistic Terms: What is a Root?". *Sil.org*. 3 December 2015. Retrieved 2021-05-14.
4. ^ "SIL Glossary of Linguistic Terms: What is a Derivational Affix?". *Sil.org*. 3 December 2015. Retrieved 2021-05-14.
5. ^ "SIL Glossary of Linguistic Terms: What is an Inflectional Affix?". *Sil.org*. 3 December 2015. Retrieved 2021-05-14.
6. ^ "SIL Glossary of Linguistic Terms: What is a Stem?". *Sil.org*. 3 December 2015. Retrieved 2021-05-14.

## External links [edit]

- The dictionary definition of *lexeme* at Wiktionary

V · T · E Lexicology [show]
V · T · E Lexicography [show]
Authority control databases [show]

Categories: Lexical units | Linguistics terminology

This page was last edited on 27 June 2025, at 19:23 (UTC).

Text is available under the Creative Commons Attribution-ShareAlike 4.0 License; additional terms may apply. By using this site, you agree to the Terms of Use and Privacy Policy. Wikipedia® is a registered trademark of the Wikimedia Foundation, Inc., a non-profit organization.

Privacy policy About Wikipedia Disclaimers Contact Wikipedia Code of Conduct Developers Statistics Cookie statement Mobile view

a WIKIMEDIA project
Powered by MediaWiki